A particularly useful officer at the provincial level was the kotwal, appointed to the provincial capitals and large cities. Fulfilling the functions of a police chief, accompanied by 200–300 policemen, the kotwal was meant to keep the peace by carrying out a bewildering number of tasks, as listed by Badauni:

> That he would keep a close watch on every one who came in or went out, of whatever degree he might be, whether merchant, soldier or otherwise; that he would not allow troublesome and disorderly fellows or thieves to take up their abode in the city; that if he saw any one whose expenditure was greater than his receipts, he would follow the matter up, and represent to the Emperor, through the chief police officer that this extravagance of his was probably paid for with money irregularly acquired…

Entirely unsurprisingly, the kotwal was ‘the most dreaded government official during the Mughal period, whose very appearance in a public place at the head of a dozen horsemen or foot-soldiers was enough to make the people tremble with fear’.

The Padshah remained the ultimate bestower of justice, however, and for this it was crucial that he remain on the move, accessible at all times. Even in his war camp, he met every day with supplicants and one day in 1564, when he was encamped near Malwa, he was approached by a woman whose daughter had been raped by Abdullah Khan Uzbek’s arms bearer. Akbar promised the woman justice and when the man was subsequently captured, during a confrontation with Abdullah Khan, he was executed.

In many ways Akbar was still at this time a rather orthodox Muslim, even as he was beginning to understand the complexities of the land. When the first embassy from Shah Tahmasp of Persia arrived bringing Persian and Anatolian horses, precious textiles, and rare objects, the shah also included a letter in which Akbar was cordially described as the ‘unsurpassed adherent of God’s word and extirpator of polytheists’.

It is clear from these many episodes that the Mughal Empire was not a preordained entity, emerging flawless from the inspired Padshah’s thoughts, as Abu’l Fazl would rather posterity imagined, but a progressive creation, evolving through discordant mistakes and brave, unforeseen changes. And even the ‘polytheists’ that the Shah of Persia fondly hoped would be